

UI/UX Design Process Cheat Sheet

A practical guide to the UI/UX design process: from understanding the problem and researching users to wireframing, UI design, prototyping, usability testing, iteration, and final handoff.

Who it's for

UI/UX students, beginner designers, career switchers, and anyone who wants a clear UX design workflow.

How to use it

Treat each step as a prompt. Pick the activities that fit your project, time, and budget, and skip what adds no value.

Important

The UX design process is iterative. You will often loop back to an earlier step when you learn something new.

The UI/UX Design Process at a Glance

01

Understand the problem

02

UX research

03

Users & needs

04

User journey

05

Information architecture

06

User flow

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Wireframing

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UI design

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01 Understand the Problem

Good design starts with a clear problem, not a screen. Before opening Figma, answer these questions with your team or client.

What problem are we solving?

Describe it in one or two sentences, without suggesting a solution.

Who has the problem?

The specific people or user groups who experience it.

Why does the problem matter?

The cost of leaving it unsolved for users and for the business.

What are the business goals?

E.g. more sign-ups, fewer support tickets, higher retention.

What are the user goals?

What users are trying to get done, in their own words.

What are the constraints?

Timeline, budget, technology, legal requirements, existing brand.

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Problem defined
- ☐ Goals defined

- ☐ Users identified
- ☐ Constraints understood

02 UX Research

UX research replaces assumptions with evidence. The right method depends on the project, the time available, and the research question you need to answer. There is no single "correct" method.

Method	What it helps you learn
User interviews	Motivations, needs, context, and pain points, in depth.
Surveys	Patterns and preferences across a larger group of people.
Observation	What people actually do, which can differ from what they say.
Competitive research	How similar products solve the problem, and where the gaps are.
Existing data analysis	Analytics, support tickets, reviews, and sales feedback you already have.
Usability research	Where people struggle when using an existing product or prototype.

RESEARCH LOOP

Research question → Method → Evidence → Insight

Example: "Why do new users abandon sign-up?" → analytics + 5 user interviews → drop-off at the phone number step → users don't understand why a phone number is required.

03 Define Users & Needs

Turn research into a shared understanding of who you are designing for. Personas should be based on real research, not invented details.

User personas
Research-based profiles of key user types.

User needs
What users require to succeed.

Goals
The outcomes users want to achieve.

Pain points
Frustrations and blockers they face today.

Behaviors
How, when, and where they act.

User segments
Groups with shared needs or behaviors.

Simple persona structure

Name & role	E.g. Priya, first-year college student
Context	Where and how they use the product
Goals	What they want to achieve
Needs	What they need from the product to get there
Pain points	What frustrates or blocks them today
Behaviors	Habits, tools used, frequency of use
Key quote	A real (anonymized) quote from research

04 Define the User Journey

A user journey map shows the experience from the user's point of view across every stage, including moments outside your product.

Journey stages

The high-level phases, e.g. discover → compare → buy → use.

User actions

What the user does at each stage.

Pain points

Where the experience breaks down or feels slow.

Opportunities

Where design can remove friction or add value.

Simple journey mapping structure

	Discover	Consider	Decide	Use
Actions				
Thoughts / feelings				
Pain points				
Opportunities				

05 Information Architecture

Information architecture (IA) organizes content so users can find what they need and understand where they are.

Content structure

What content exists and how it groups together.

Navigation

How users move between areas.

Page hierarchy

Parent and child pages; the sitemap.

Categories

Logical groups that match users' mental models.

Labels

Clear, familiar names for menus and sections.

Validation

Card sorting or tree testing when helpful.

IA CHECKLIST

- ☐ Content inventory listed
- ☐ Sitemap / page hierarchy drafted
- ☐ Important content reachable in few steps
- ☐ Pages grouped into clear categories
- ☐ Navigation labels use users' language
- ☐ Structure checked with users where possible

06 User Flow

A user flow maps the steps a user takes to complete one specific task. It helps you spot missing screens, dead ends, and unnecessary steps before wireframing.

Entry point

Where the user starts (ad, search, home, email).

User action

What they do on each screen.

Decision point

Where the path branches (yes / no, logged in / not).

Next step

Where each choice leads.

Completion

The moment the task is done.

Edge cases

Errors, empty states, and going back.

EXAMPLE FLOW

Landing Page



Explore



Select



Details



Action



Confirmation

07 Wireframing

Wireframes are simple layouts that focus on structure, not style. Start with low-fidelity wireframes (paper or grey boxes) so ideas are cheap to change.

Low-fidelity wireframes

Quick sketches or boxes to explore many layout ideas fast.

Layout

Where the main blocks of content and actions sit.

Content hierarchy

What users should see first, second, and third.

Navigation & main interactions

How users move and what they can click, tap, or enter.

WIREFRAME CHECKLIST

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Layout defined | ☐ Content hierarchy clear |
| ☐ Navigation considered | ☐ Main user flow represented |
| ☐ Important states considered (empty, loading, error, success) | |

08 UI Design

UI design turns approved wireframes into a clear, consistent, and visually polished interface.

Element	What to focus on
Visual hierarchy	Size, weight, color, and spacing guide attention to what matters most.
Typography	Readable body text, clear heading levels, and a limited set of text styles.
Color	Consistent color roles (primary, text, background, feedback) with enough contrast.
Spacing	A consistent spacing scale (e.g. multiples of 4 or 8px).
Grid	Columns and margins that keep layouts aligned across breakpoints.
Components	Reusable buttons, inputs, cards, and navigation with defined states.
Design system	Shared styles, components, and rules that keep the product consistent.

UI REVIEW CHECKLIST

- ☐ Clear visual hierarchy on every screen
- ☐ Text and UI elements have enough contrast
- ☐ Layouts align to the grid
- ☐ Hover, focus, disabled, and error states designed
- ☐ Text styles consistent and readable
- ☐ Spacing follows one scale
- ☐ Components reused, not redrawn
- ☐ Mobile and desktop layouts checked

09 Prototyping

Prototypes let people experience a design before it is built. They reveal problems early, when they are still cheap to fix, and help stakeholders understand the idea.

Low-fidelity prototypes

Linked sketches or wireframes to test flow and structure.

High-fidelity prototypes

Close to the final UI, for testing details and interactions.

Interactive flows

Clickable paths through a key task, from start to completion.

Prototype testing

Put the prototype in front of users and watch what happens.

PROTOTYPE LOOP

Prototype



Test



Observe



Improve



10 Usability Testing

Usability testing shows whether real people can complete key tasks with your design. Even a small number of sessions can reveal the biggest issues.

Step	What to do
1. Define the objective	What do you need to learn? E.g. "Can users find and book a session?"
2. Create tasks	Realistic scenarios that don't reveal the answer or UI labels.
3. Recruit participants	People who match your target users, not only colleagues.
4. Observe behavior	Watch and listen. Avoid helping or leading the participant.
5. Record findings	Note where people hesitate, fail, or get confused, and what they say.
6. Identify patterns	Group repeated issues across participants.
7. Prioritize issues	Rank by severity and how many users were affected.

USABILITY TESTING CHECKLIST

- ☐ Testing objective written
- ☐ Tasks and scenarios prepared
- ☐ Prototype or product ready to test
- ☐ Appropriate participants recruited
- ☐ Consent and recording set up
- ☐ Sessions observed without leading
- ☐ Findings recorded and grouped
- ☐ Issues prioritized for iteration

11 Iteration

UX design is iterative rather than a strictly linear process. Each round of feedback improves the design and reduces risk before development.



Tip: fix the highest-impact issues first. Not every piece of feedback needs a change; look for patterns and evidence.

12 Final Design & Handoff

A good handoff helps developers build what was designed without guesswork. Include everything they need in one organized place.

Final UI

Approved screens, clearly named and organized.

Components

Reusable components with all their states and variants.

Design tokens / styles

Colors, typography, spacing, radius, and shadows.

Responsive states

How layouts adapt across mobile, tablet, and desktop.

Interaction specifications

Transitions, hover/focus, loading, and error behavior.

Prototype

A linked prototype showing the intended flows.

Assets

Exported icons, images, and logos in the right formats.

Developer notes

Edge cases, content rules, and open questions.

HANDOFF CHECKLIST

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Final screens approved and labeled | ☐ Components and variants documented |
| ☐ Design tokens / styles defined | ☐ Responsive layouts provided |
| ☐ Interaction and state specs written | ☐ Prototype linked |
| ☐ Assets exported | ☐ Developer notes and edge cases added |
| ☐ Handoff walkthrough with developers done | ☐ Plan for design QA during build |

13 Measure & Learn

After launch, check whether the design worked. The appropriate metrics depend on the project and its goals. Choose a few that connect to the problem you defined in step 01.

User feedback

Comments, reviews, and support messages.

Usability findings

Results from follow-up testing.

Task success

Can users complete key tasks?

Conversion

Sign-ups, purchases, or bookings.

Engagement

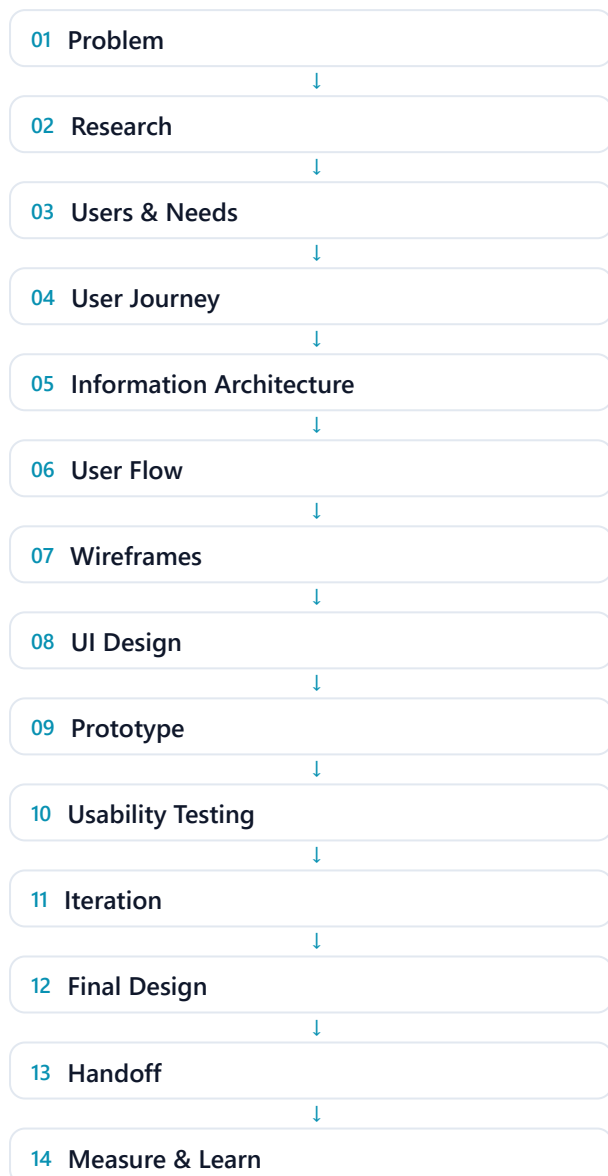
Return visits and feature usage.

Business & product metrics

Retention, revenue, fewer support tickets.

14 Complete UI/UX Workflow

The full UI/UX design process on one page.



Real projects do not always follow this process in a

perfectly linear order. Designers may move between research, flows, wireframes, prototypes, and testing as new information is discovered.

Common loops in practice

Usability testing → back to wireframes or UI design

New research insight → update personas, journey, or user flow

Measure & learn → a new problem to solve, and the process starts again

15 Quick UI/UX Process Checklist

Run through this before sharing a project or handing it off.

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Problem understood | ☐ Users identified |
| ☐ Goals defined | ☐ Research completed |
| ☐ Insights documented | ☐ User needs identified |
| ☐ Journey mapped | ☐ Information architecture considered |
| ☐ User flow created | ☐ Wireframes created |
| ☐ UI designed | ☐ Prototype created |
| ☐ Usability tested | ☐ Feedback analyzed |
| ☐ Design iterated | ☐ Final design reviewed |
| ☐ Handoff prepared | ☐ Outcomes measured where possible |

16 Beginner Tips

Don't jump straight into visual design

Structure and flow come before colors and fonts.

Understand the problem before designing

A beautiful solution to the wrong problem still fails.

Talk to users when appropriate

Even a few conversations can change your direction.

Explain why you made design decisions

Link each decision to research, goals, or testing.

Test ideas early

Test sketches and wireframes, not only the final UI.

Iterate based on evidence

Use findings and patterns, not personal preference.

Keep users and business goals in view

Good UX serves both at the same time.

Document the process for your portfolio

Save research notes, sketches, and versions as you go.

17 Related UI/UX Resources

Free resources from NSL Digital Lab that go deeper into each step.

Resource	Use it for
UX Research Starter Kit	Research planning, interviews, personas, and affinity mapping (steps 02–03)
Figma Website Wireframe Kit	Starter wireframe screens and frame sizes (step 07)
UI Design Checklist	Reviewing typography, spacing, color, and components (step 08)
Figma Shortcuts Cheat Sheet	Working faster in Figma while wireframing and prototyping
Website Usability Checklist	Reviewing navigation, forms, and mobile usability (steps 10–11)
UX Case Study Template	Presenting this process as a portfolio case study
